By the Dawn's Early Light

By Ahmad Nuruddin

INTRODUCTION

Black, white, and Latino—Americans from every race and religion are increasingly accepting and converting to Islam. Why, you ask? Aren't the radical extremists who are terrorizing our world a part of the Islamic faith? The answer is yes, but just like any religion, there are fanatics who go overboard. Look at Fred Phelps, and the intolerant image he presents of Christianity -- Is that what Christianity is? No more than the acts of terrorists define the religion of Islam. And at a time when our nation is seeing a rise in intolerant behavior, crossing every cultural line, whether based on race, religion or sexual orientation, Islam teaches tolerance, justice and honor, and promotes patience, modesty and balance. By the Dawn's Early Light, presents forty engaging autobiographical essays by American converts to Islam, and helps to explain why. This is the story of Noel Durham (also known as Ahmad Nuruddin).

I was born Noel Durham in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania in 1972. Along with two brothers, Joseph and Nathaniel, and sister, Marie, I was raised in a

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pseudo-Christian household. We were raised to believe in God and know right from wrong, but I cannot say we were involved with religion more than that.

Our grandparents were practicing Baptists and when my siblings and I visited them we would attend church regularly. My mother was a housewife, tending to her children's upbringing primarily, while my stepfather worked for a pipe supply company.

I went to public school and I still remember my mother stressing the importance of education throughout my childhood. As a family we did not have many means - luxuries were sacrificed in order for all of us to excel in education. It is a tribute to my mother that all of us did, despite the inner-city environment, obtain good grades and stay out of trouble.

I was also a good athlete, playing basketball and football when I was younger. In high school, I replaced basketball with wrestling but still kept playing football. I played both offensive and defensive tackle for the football team and became the captain during my senior year at Abraham Lincoln High

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School. I also wrestled as a heavyweight, which is the 225 pound-plus weight class. Our team won the citywide championship every year from my sophomore year onwards, and my personal record was 30-3.

During my junior year of high school, my elder brother Joseph came home from college during a holiday and said he is a Muslim and does not eat pork. At the time, it was a 'thing' in Philadelphia, kind of fashionable you can say, to give up pork to try to purify oneself. This was my first real contact with Islam.

While my family members were not antagonistic, they were a bit curious as to why this sudden change had come about in Joseph. I also had a cousin, Rashid, who was the same age as me and identified with the teachings of the Nation of Islam.

One time, Rashid gave me a Muslim head cap as a gift and I wore it the entire day because I liked the look. Surprisingly enough, throughout the entire day people would pass when I was walking on the street and say, "Assalaamu alaykum." This may not be a big deal

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to some folks, but those who are familiar the hustle-bustle lifestyle of any major American city know people just don't stop to say hello. When I found out that these people were wishing peace upon me simply because they assumed I was a Muslim, a small attraction began to develop for Islam.

After graduating from high school I enrolled at Indiana University (IU) in Pennsylvania, the same college my brother Joseph had attended. I continued to pray to God in times of trial or joy. This belief in God is due in part to the training my grandparents instilled in me. I would visit the church near campus sometimes and experienced more of what I had seen while at home - singing and dancing, but no real guidance on personal development and refinement.

By the Grace of God, despite some hard times, I earned my Bachelor's in Marketing in 1990.

When I returned home to start work, I found Islam was even more popular in Philadelphia. Muslim men, however, had become known for committing crimes and being abusive towards women. I remembered that when

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I was a child I had dream in which I had been in a car accident; it seemed as though I was hovering above the scene, and after the accident, I sat down in the median. The dream was strange as I had never been in an accident. I don't know why I recalled that dream following college. Anyways, one night my brother Joseph and I decided to visit our alma mater and on the way back, the car went out of control and violently flipped off the highway. Alhamdolillah, Joseph and I survived with only a few minor bumps and bruises.

A few months later I spotted an exact replica of the car that we were in during the accident. The car had a personalized license plate that said "B Ready." I found this very peculiar and feverishly prayed for God to show me the truth.

I began studying Islam and the Holy Qur'an. I noticed that if I had problem, I would open the Qur'an and eventually arrive on something that addressed the problem. Before I had finished half the Qur'an, I knew it was a living book from God. Eventually, I completed the entire English translation. I prayed, "If

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this is the truth, God, please guide me and allow me to fully understand and implement its teachings."

Thereafter I started to discuss my impressions of the Quran with friends. I also visited a few mosques but was disappointed at the lack of love and brotherhood the Muslims showed me simply because I was not a Muslim, at the time. One day, after a game of basketball with my cousin Rashid and some of his friends, three of the brothers asked if we would like to visit the mosque to offer prayers and eat. I did not know that these three brothers, Idrees Mahmood, Daud Mahmood, and Usman Abdul Karim, were Ahmadi Muslims at the time.

After we had offered prayers and eaten, we began a discussion on Islam and I was very impressed that they took an interest in my education of Islam. The first question they asked was whether I knew how to perform prayers in Arabic. As I did not, they began teaching me the entire prayer. I actually learned Surah Al-Fatihah that very day. Over a three-month span, I learned the fundamentals of Islam, the true story of

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Jesus Christ, and who the Promised Messiah and his successors were. I also became firmly grounded in the life of Prophet Muhammad. In fact, the first book I finished was Life of Muhammad by Mirza Bashiruddin Mahmood Ahmad, the Second Khalifa.

The pictures of the Promised Messiah and his successors had a profound impact on me. I was amazed that I was given that chance to actually see the face of a prophet of God as well as that of his noble successors. I knew this place, the Nasir Mosque, was the place to learn about Islam.

About a month after my first visit, in 1997, I joined the Ahmadiyya Muslim Community, under the watchful and loving eye of Imam Mubasher Ahmad. At that time, many brothers helped me pick out a new name. I wanted some connection to the Promised Messiah, so I chose "Ahmad," the "one who praises," as my first name. Learning that the Promised Messiah wished all of his followers to be like his First Khalifa, Hakim Nuruddin, I chose "Nuruddin," "light of the faith," as my last name.

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I was very impressed with the fact that these brothers, despite being American, could recite the Qur'an in fluid and beautiful Arabic, and it made me want to be at par with them. At that time, an elder brother, Rashid, came to the mosque weekly to hold an Arabic class. Within three months time, Alhamdolillah, I became fluent in the recitation of the Qur'an in Arabic. The first chapter I then memorized was Surah al-Ikhlas.

While the demographic of Nasir Mosque was seventy percent Pakistani and thirty percent African-American, 100% of the brothers were honorable and honest people. I was enamored with the atmosphere as there was no backbiting or foul language, and all the brothers were highly educated and sincere. In particular, there was a brother named Munir Hamid, who I still recall was a striking figure because of his character and mannerisms.

Initiation into the Ahmadiyya Muslim Community has made me a much more refined and spiritually awakened human being. In both my walk and

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talk, those around me, especially my family, have seen a marked difference. I feel as though entering into this Community is akin to finding a fountain after wandering through a desert for one's entire life. There is no way I can leave this fountain now. I am 100% confident that I am following the correct teachings of the Qur'an and Prophet Muhammad.

Our youth group, Khuddamul Ahmadiyya, is a beautiful organization that allows the youth to quickly mature into men - becoming educated in both religious and secular studies. Many of our Khuddam are honorable young men who take education seriously and I feel it is very rare to be amongst such young people who are not engaged in the nonsense so many others most unfortunately fall victim to.

By the grace of Allah, in 2002, 1 married a woman who had converted to the Ahmadiyya Muslim Community one year prior. Allah has blessed us with three beautiful daughters.

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